

HEX

A cave-diving roguelite of unstable power, every weapon is on a burning fuse.

Game Link: <https://krishnarishik.github.io/Hex/>

GitHub Link: <https://github.com/KrishnaRishik/Hex>

Question 3: Design Specification (survivor-like feature)

Feature: "The Swarm Learns", an adaptive adversary that drafts against your build

Rationale (why this feature). Survivor-likes are dopamine-rich but decision-poor: after the first few minutes your build outpaces the horde and the run becomes solved, you're watching numbers, not making choices. The mid-run upgrade picks, the genre's one real decision, lose their stakes the moment you know the optimal path. "The Swarm Learns" attacks that central weakness **without** adding input complexity (combat stays fully auto): the horde reacts to your build, so every upgrade pick becomes a read-and-counter against an opponent instead of a lookup. It keeps the genre's signature choice meaningful across the whole run, and it manufactures "I outsmarted the swarm" stories the genre currently can't tell.

Design intent (how it works).

A director tracks your **dominant damage profile** (heavy projectile, AoE/burn, melee aura, crit/burst) via a rolling tally of where your damage comes from.

Every 90 seconds it adapts, introducing a counter-archetype to your dominant profile: go all-projectile and it spawns fast, weaving flankers that punish straight-line aim; go all AoE and it spawns sparse, high-HP elites that AoE can't farm efficiently.

Adaptations are **telegraphed one wave ahead** the next level-up draft is seeded with at least one pick that answers the incoming counter, so you can always respond, but you have to *notice* and *choose* to.

When the director commits to an adaptation, a thin banner slides across the top of the play field, *"The Swarm is adapting to your fire"* with a small icon of the incoming counter-archetype and a countdown ring lasting fewer second. This is information meant to provoke a *decision*. The countdown does two jobs at once. It gives a skilled player a window to reposition before the wave lands, and it builds a beat of anticipation so the wave arrives as a payoff rather than a surprise. The player can literally *see* the swarm's answer on the field. Crucially it is never forced: the counter sits beside the usual greedy upgrades, so the player chooses between pressing their build harder or bending to answer the swarm. That one recurring choice, *"commit or adapt"* is the entire engine of the feature, and it repeats with rising stakes at every adaptation tier.

